



Miracle moment:

Dhakshineswar Suresh falls to the ground after match point as his teammates rush to congratulate him after winning the Davis Cup Qualifier round one tie against the Netherlands.

Pics: K. MURALI KUMAR

Not since the great Leander Paes in 2004 had someone managed the feat of winning three matches in a single tie for India. A promising junior player a decade ago, setbacks during the Covid-19 pandemic and his ongoing education at Wake Forest University in the United States had largely kept Dhakshineswar **(right)** out of the spotlight for Indian fans. It was only last September, during the Davis Cup World Group I tie against Switzerland, that the man with a 6'5" frame shot to fame.

On his Cup debut, he beat Jerome Kym, a player ranked more than 450 places above him at the time, to give India a rousing start that translated into a fine 3-1 triumph. **Now, with three wins against the Netherlands, he has an astonishing 4-0 win-loss record from his first four outings, propelling India to rare back-to-back victories over European opposition.**

Dhakshineswar's effort was all the more noteworthy because Nagal lost both his

matches. He wasn't slated to play doubles, but in the intervening night between day one and day two, Rajpal & Co. decided to thrust Dhakshineswar ahead of Sriram Balaji to take advantage of the gangly man's giant serve — a successful experiment in hindsight.

On day two alone, Dhakshineswar spent a total of four hours and 39 minutes on court, a fine display of grit, stamina and pressure-handling skills. "It's a different feeling when you're playing for your country," he said after the win. "You're not just playing for yourself, you're playing for the whole nation. I played some different tennis in these matches, and I'm really proud of that," he added.

For Indian tennis, the result brings some much-needed relief. First, the rise of Dhakshineswar is a genuine green shoot. There is now an expectation that once he graduates this summer from university and starts playing regularly on the ATP Tour, he will rise swiftly in the rankings and become the top-100 player India is desperately seeking.

Second, the Netherlands feat takes the country back to a level in the global tennis hierarchy it last reached in 2011, when it was in the elite 16-team World Group in the erstwhile Cup format.

Reaching that stage is in no way a reflection of the current state of the game in India, for player-development activities are not widespread or professional, and the country has negligible presence in singles at the Slam level. But if the governing bodies can channel the positive energy generated to help rejuvenate the sport, this could become one of Indian tennis' seminal moments.

